immigrants, both in trade and business. Slowly but surely, Indians are waking up to the prospect of settling all over Africa.

Ponte all'Indiano: Bridging Europe and India

When sleepy Indians arrive in London's Heathrow airport and open their eyes to long immigration queues, they can barely identify which country they are in. At first sight, virtually all the attendants at the airport look like them. It's only when they speak in a British-Indian accent that the Indian passengers are jolted wide awake. Heathrow airport is located in west London, around Southall, one of the densest South Asian tracts in Britain, which explains why so many Indians work at the airport. But how did so many people from South Asia manage to get there in the first place? How did the United Kingdom get its nearly 2-million-strong population of Indian origin comprising over 2 per cent of its population?

Some of the first Indians in western Europe went there as sailors and nannies, usually called lascars and ayahs, as part of imperial connections. Since 1690, the East India Company documents record the presence of Indians on ships heading towards England.[25] Much later, the princes and maharajas of India and their families spent lavish vacations in England as part of the deals with imperial forces. In the 19th century, in addition to lascars and ayahs, a greater variety of migrants went to Britain including students, artists, jugglers and the proverbial snake-charmers.[26]

Two Indians had little to do with snakes but still managed to charm the political establishment in the 19th century. Dadabhai Naoroji worked in Britain for decades and was the first Indian to become a member of the British parliament in the 1890s, winning the election by a narrow margin of five votes and proceeding to champion causes favouring India. At quite another level, Abdul Karim from Jhansi in British India, working as a prison clerk in Agra, was shipped to England in 1887 for a particular task during Queen Victoria's golden jubilee celebrations. It was by chance that he caught the fancy of the queen who made him her personal attendant